

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 33

Culture (OWC): [Gusii \(FL08\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1946-1949

Coverage Date: 1946-1949

Place Coverage

Kavirondo Gulf region of Lake Victoria, western Kenya, East Africa

Section Title(S): Real And Courtesy Generations

The general 'finding out how to call one another' does more than fix reciprocal etiquette patterns between two people. It guarantees that there will be no confusion *vis-à-vis* third parties. When a 'small father in the clan' and his 'child in the clan' meet in company, e.g. at someone else's beer drink or ceremony, one will find himself allotted to the group which behaves familiarly with the host, the other to the group which behaves familiarly with the host's son, or father. If a beer drink is being held in the host's *eero* (outer room) the generations can mingle, for in *nsoni* terms this does not necessarily count as 'entering his house': but it is clear to everyone which guests can come in through the other room of the hut (the main living-room and bedroom) and which must enter through the cattle pen and 'outside door'. And this in turn is a clear index as to who can or cannot address the host's wife in familiar terms, or make jokes with her, or engage in any kind of horseplay. The distinctions of *nsoni* matter less when people are in the fields, or on the way, than they do in the homestead, where most of the tabooed objects are concentrated (beds, stools, etc.). But most Gusii joint activities, including rituals and ceremonies, take place in a homestead, the hut or the cattle pen serving for shrine or gathering-place. In any friendly relation, then, common decency requires people to be able to place one another in kin-term categories.

527
[Rest Days And Holidays](#)

576
[Etiquette](#)

601
[Kinship Terminology](#)

602
[Kin Relationships](#)

614
[Clans](#)

784
[Avoidance And Taboo](#)

When a storm broke suddenly, a man took shelter with us in a half-finished hut at the edge of a homestead. He did not know whose the homestead was, but it was in another sub-clan of his own clan. To be on the safe side he remained standing, although there was a stool in the hut. A young man came in and announced himself as the owner. The two men had never met before, but proceeded to 'find out' that they were to 'call each other brother/cousin' (*momura ominto*). This showed that the stool could be used; it was offered and accepted. On another occasion a man accompanying us to a funeral ceremony, in the clan community bordering on his own, asked the way from an old woman. After a lengthy preliminary process of 'finding out' he stepped forward and shook her hand, explaining for our benefit that 'it seems I must

527
[Rest Days And Holidays](#)

576
[Etiquette](#)

601
[Kinship Terminology](#)

602
[Kin Relationships](#)

call her "grandmother" (*magokoro*). (*Abansoni* cannot shake hands.) Because it is impossible to carry on friendly intercourse without observing these basic decencies (as Gusii regard them), the 'finding out of relations' necessarily extends to all kin, connections, friends and friendly acquaintance, outside as well as inside one's own clan and clan-community.

614

Clans

784

Avoidance And Taboo

Mother, wives, married sisters, married daughters: each of a man's demonstrable kin (including affines) is the point of entry to a universe of courtesy categorizations, as well as a branch of the demonstrable kindred. In his mother's clan of origin ego has 'the' *mame* (maternal uncle) *par excellence* —the mother's cattle-linked brother, who owes the *emesuto* gift; he also has his other 'real *abamame*' (pl. of *mame*) who however are 'not so near'—the mother's true classificatory brother/cousins, her same-generation agnates in her own *riiga*, who are  34 presumptive understudies to 'the' *mame*. But thirdly, *mame* can extend for courtesy purposes to everyone else in the mother's natal clan whom the mother 'calls brother/cousin'. This third type is the 'not-real' *mame*.

576

Etiquette

601

Kinship Terminology

602

Kin Relationships

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